CORE-05 | Therapist guide only

A small action serving a personal direction

Core 05: planning meaningful action suited to current ability, preferences and circumstances.

Purpose of this unit

Connect a chosen goal to a possible everyday action. Consider effort, resources and needed help. There is no requirement to stay busier or act to prove motivation.

Connecting with previous work

Open with SES-S01. Revisit the goal and learning from Core 4, and check whether chosen wording or a response could support action. Starting with current functioning rather than cognitive work is also possible.

Suggested sequence

1. Explore what matters to the client and what they want to do in life.
2. Describe current circumstances and choose an observable action.
3. Reduce it to a step that fits now, with a smaller version if needed.
4. Agree on time, place, preparation and desired support, and explore real barriers.
5. Choose a brief way to learn from the attempt and close with SES-S02.

Choosing the scope

The step may be brief or partial; rest or adjusted conditions may also be needed. There is no uniform scope by age or requirement for steadily increasing effort. Consider limitations and the relevant clinical situation.

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Examples of choosing and reducing a step

These examples are fictional illustrations. Actual choices are made with the client.

Group	A possible direction and adaptation
Children	The child wants to join a game. Instead of a full afternoon, choose learning one rule in a chosen game with agreed help. Check that the step matters to and suits the child.
Adolescents	The teenager wants to return to an interest. The step may be preparing materials for a brief start, without requiring a finished result or sharing it.
Adults	The client wants to make room for an important relationship. Start by choosing a suitable time for contact or clarifying the desired kind of contact, given the circumstances.
Older adults	The person wants to restore a meaningful activity. Explore what is possible now and the access adjustments or support they want, without deciding what is age-appropriate for them.

When the goal comes from someone else

Ask what the client wants and what it means to them. Parent, school or family expectations add information but do not replace collaborative choice.

When starting is difficult

Explore whether the step is unclear, too large, unwanted or lacks a needed resource. Do not assume every barrier is a mistaken thought. Change the action, reduce its scope or seek appropriate help.

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Adapting to age and circumstances

Preserve the client's voice and choice of support alongside clinical assessment of suitability.

Group	How to work
Children	One concrete action and a simple description of starting. An adult may help with reminders or preparation in an agreed role, without turning practice into a test or punishment.
Adolescents	Explore personal meaning, privacy and the actual schedule. Offer choices between actions, not only doing or not doing.
Adults	Include roles, demands, financial conditions and resources as described; do not assume time or help is available.
Older adults	Respect preferences and life experience. Ask about pace, access and help as needed without assuming reduced ability.

Checking understanding

Ask the client to describe what they will do, when and what could help. If unclear, revise together. Prepare the step during the session if suitable.

Adjusting along the way

Ability and willingness can change. Changed conditions require a fresh look, not a finding of broken commitment. An action does not replace needed treatment or professional adaptation.

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Brief review and choosing what comes next

CORE-05-P supports planning a reminder and recording after the attempt.

At the next meeting

Return to the plan and what was done, exploring experience and effects on functioning. Check what helped and what was hard, beyond whether a box says completed. Not starting may also indicate a need for adjustment.

What to take forward

Keep an action, change its scope or choose another. Progress does not require immediate emotional relief. A persistent practical barrier may become the focus of Core 6.

Content status

Original guide and worksheets in draft. Professional and rights reviews are required for each age and language. The unit number does not prescribe a session count or a validated treatment protocol.

General sources for further reading

Beck Institute Cares: What Are CBT Sessions Like?
General background on collaboration, goals and action planning.
https://cares.beckinstitute.org/about-cbt/what-are-sessions-like/

Beck Institute: Selecting Techniques in CBT
Background on adapting the approach to the person and goal.
https://beckinstitute.org/blog/selecting-techniques-in-cbt/

Consulted: 03 Nov 2026. Sources neither license external forms nor validate the kit or its age adaptations.

Reviewer's name, role, date and versions reviewed:

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